

WASHINGTON DC-AREA MUSIC CENSUS



Photo Courtesy of District of Columbia Commission on the Arts and Humanities

SUMMARY REPORT October 2024



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Executive Summary

The 2024 DC-Area Music Census was a community-led initiative to gain a better understanding of the current needs of the Greater Washington, DC-area music community. The music census launched on April 10, 2024 and ran for seven weeks and collected 2,738 responses from people working in music in any capacity who are 18 years or older and living in the greater Washington, DC-area.

The DC-area music ecosystem is predominantly composed of individuals in the Music Creative sector (79%), with smaller representations in Industry (13%) and Venue/Presenter roles (8%), noting that we like to see Industry closer to 20%. Increasing the Venue/Presenters segment to support Creatives may bring more balance.

81% of Music Creative respondents have over 10 years of experience. Their primary income sources are local live performances (33%), teaching (17%), and touring (24%). Performance frequency varies, with many Creatives lacking local paid gigs and a disparity in pay between local (\$446) and touring performances (\$136). Key career concerns include the rising cost of living (43%), stagnant pay rates (33%), and lack of music work (27%). Creative respondents in the DC-area spend an average of \$7,969 annually on music-related expenses, 50% of which stays local for an annual spend collectively of \$17M.

Venue/Presenter respondents show a gender distribution of 48% men and 42% women. Ownership is predominantly for-profit (47%), with significant nonprofit (36%) and informal setups (11%). Live music venues (24%) are the most common, followed by festivals (15%) and independent promoters (12%). Venue capacities vary widely, with most accommodating 1-200 people, and 69% offering outdoor capabilities. Respondents host an average of 95 live events annually, contributing to a total of 13,567 live events each year.

Venue/Presenter respondents face significant regulatory challenges, with sound policy (22%) and permit costs (28%) being top concerns, while confusion and inefficiency in processes (27%) also pose issues. Venues and Presenters express a strong preference for regulatory tools like tax discounts (70%), online portals for permitting (69%), and having an advocate inside the government (69%).

Music significantly contributes to the economy of the DC-area, generating \$63 million annually across all respondents. It accounts for 22% of respondents' income, averaging \$23,000 per year from music. Additionally, 68% work outside of music, with 88% relying on their external job for primary income, highlighting the economic challenges in the music industry.

In terms of developing the music ecosystem, the DC-area music ecosystem faces significant challenges in commercial workspace availability, with the majority of venues and spaces being rented rather than owned. Desired resources include collaboration spaces (56%) and affordable rehearsal spaces (53%). Venues and Presenters prioritize business resources to boost audience development (79%) and support for local music scene infrastructure. The primary locations for music-related work are concentrated in Northwest DC (73%), highlighting regional activity hubs within the metro area.

The DC-area music ecosystem is generally livable and offers many positive experiences. The DC-area music ecosystem's cultural greatest strengths are that it is non-homophobic (85%), safe (84%), inclusive (76%), and diverse (75%). The DC-area music ecosystem cultural challenges are elitism (51%), ageism (48%), sexism (42%), and competitiveness (41%).

This report and the online dashboard available at DCMusicCensus.org offer more in-depth data, insights, and opportunities to understand, support, and grow the DC-area's diverse music ecosystem and all the benefits it offers culturally and economically.

Introduction

The 2024 DC-Area Music Census was a community-led initiative to gain a better understanding of the current needs of the Greater Washington, DC-area music community. The census captures key information about the DC-area music economy to help the community make more informed, data-driven decisions to support the music ecosystem.

The music census launched on April 10, 2024 and ran for seven weeks. The study was open to all people working in music in any capacity who are 18 years or older and living in the greater Washington, DC-area including Virginia and Maryland, and it was offered in English and Spanish. The census was administered by [Sound Music Cities](#), a leading Austin-based provider of music ecosystem studies and music census work, in conjunction with the DC Commission on the Arts & Humanities, the state arts organization of the District of Columbia. DC joined a multi-city cohort program administered by Sound Music Cities which met monthly to discuss best practices on improving music industries on a city level, allowing DC to gain insight from other cities conducting similar research.

This summary report has been prepared by Sound Music Cities and includes an overview of the Music Ecosystem Health Assessment based on 10 key indicator areas. The report includes key findings and recommendations. Alongside this report, Sound Music Cities has provided access to an online dashboard where you can find more data at DCMusicCensus.org.

INTRODUCTION TO A MUSIC CENSUS

Any strategy to support and grow a music ecosystem begins with a basic understanding of its population. Professional music communities are not easily discoverable using traditional methods (such as through labor statistics or economic data). A music census collects key data points to better understand music people and their economic activity within a specific geography. It provides a baseline for policymakers and the larger community to understand and take action.

The value of a music census goes well beyond the data itself. Such initiatives ignite a range of activities that are conducive to more strategic and sustainable support for local music scenes over the long term, beginning with validating this economically marginalized group, sharing new learning, activating civic and community resources, and ultimately empowering music people to take ownership of change initiatives.

2,738 responses

April 10-May29, 2024

8% venue/presenter

13% industry

79% music creatives



Photos Courtesy of District of Columbia Commission on the Arts and Humanities

A Community Effort

The 2024 study was led by a group of 5 Lead Partners. This study took a grassroots approach that engaged local partners who hold the relationships with music people. Community Partners served as the primary means of outreach to music people and these organizations were instrumental in shaping the Census itself.

Thank you to our amazing Lead Partners and Community Partners

LEAD PARTNERS

DC Commission on the Arts and Humanities
DC Mayor's Office of Nightlife and Culture
DC Office of Cable Television Film Music and Entertainment
Arlington Arts
Arts Fairfax

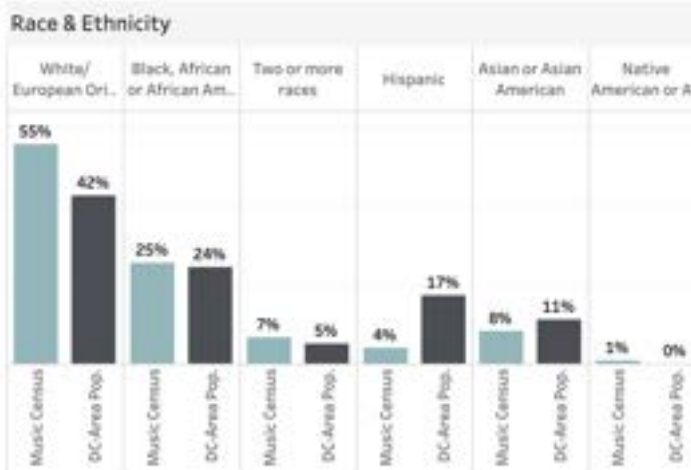
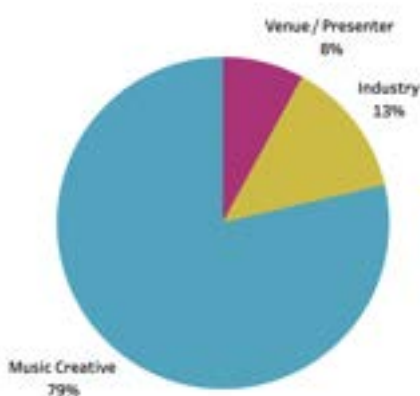
COMMUNITY PARTNERS

24-7 Booking	DMV Music Alliance	Jim Barratt	Ric Peters
7 Drum City/ The Pocket	Dontourage Records	John Brooks	Ricardo Abbott
Aden Jacobs	Earl Jackson	Jonathan Mangual	Rock Creek Kings
Alex Hamburger	East of the River Steel Bands	Josh Heit	Ronald Goodman
All Things Go	Eaton Workshop	Jungle Habitat Ent	Ronald Hall
Allive Agency	Edwin Ndzeh	JV Restaurant	Roxplosion
Amy Domingues	Electric Cowbell Records	KC Malone	Russell Taylor
Andre Deleo	Elin Melgarejo	Kiena Kennedy	Saki Marki Percussions
Andrew Myles	Ericka Fitzpatrick	Kopius Media	Sandi Redman
Ardamus	Erika Wood	LeeAnn King	Sarah Weiner
Backyard Band	Errica Poindexter	Leona Roskowski	Scott Tucker
Barry Jones	Fairouz Foty	Little Drummer Boys & Girls of Washington	Setoria LLC
Black Alley	Femme Fatal DC	Long Live Go Go	Shayvon Studios
Body of Evidence Band	Fs Music/The Fatal 9 Series/Fatal Sinz	Louis Diene Faye Foundation	Simone Baron
Bradie Frink	Fuse Box Radio	Malcolm Carroll	Simone Ruth
Bryce Rudow	Future Band DC	Malika Sells Homes	Sirius Company
Camilla Younger	Garvey	Marcos Cisneros	SPVCECULTco LLC
Cantate Chamber Singers	Gary Goodman	Mark J Smith	Supa Radio DMV
Capital City Symphony	Genesis Poets Music	Matt Flemming	Terrance Cooper
Cathedral Choral Society	George Belton	Maura Moore	Terrence Sorrell
Changamire	Girls Rock DC	Miami Takeover	Tha City Kidz
Christopher Prince	Global Music Exchange	Mirlo	The Consortium
Chuck Levins	Go Go Over Everything	New Level Entertainment	The Delarcos
Culture House DC	Go Go Royalty	Noochie	The T.A. Cook Agency
Cumbia Heights	GoGoMusic Radio	NYCHI Production & Entertainment	Theater Washington
Cynthia Bowles	Grammy U	Odyssey Band of DC	This Week At DC
DA*Aftermath Band	Greenbelt Honk! Situation	Open Gems	Tom Koutsoumpas
Daniel Newton	Heritage Signature Chorale	Palisades Hub	True Friends Film
Dark Squad Entertainment	Home Rule Music & Film	Peace + Happyness	UCB
DC Blues Society	Hung Tao Choy Mei Leadership Institute	Peacemakers Band	Velu Ochoa
DC Fray	I.M.P	Phat Cats Entertainment	Vincent Sims
DC Music Summit	Ibrahima Kebe	Pie Shop DC	Vinyl District
DC Soul Sounds LLC	Jah Kente International Inc	Pipkin Creative	Vivian Podgainsy
DC Vybe Band	James Reingold	Project Purpose	Von Vargas
DC9 Nightclub	James Zimmerman	Quintango	Washington Bach Consort
DCBX	Jassie Rios	Ramon Carrero	Will brown
Determined 2 Crank	Jazz Cat Herder	Raquel Brown	William Gorham
Distinguished entertainment LLC	Jess Forrester	Rare Essence	Work Flora
District Kings	Jessica Johnson	Rhizome DC	YahZarah
DJ Baby G	Jill Greenleight		Yendy Brown

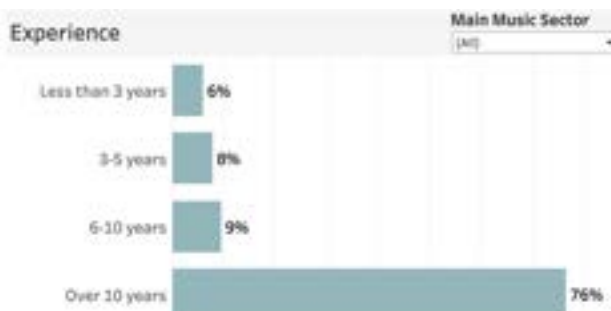
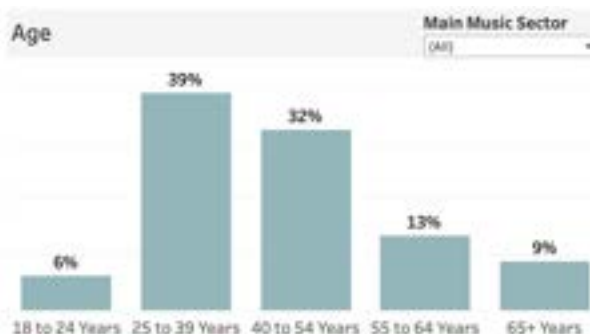
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition

The majority of respondents in the music ecosystem are from the Creative sector, making up 79% of the total. The Industry sector represents 13%, while Venue/Presenter respondents constitute 8%, noting that we like to see Industry closer to 20%. In terms of racial and ethnic diversity, the music census participants are predominantly White/European origin (55%), followed by Black/African American (25%), with smaller representations from other racial groups. This composition highlights a significant dominance of Creative professionals, with Industry and Venue/Presenter sectors forming a smaller but essential part of the music scene.

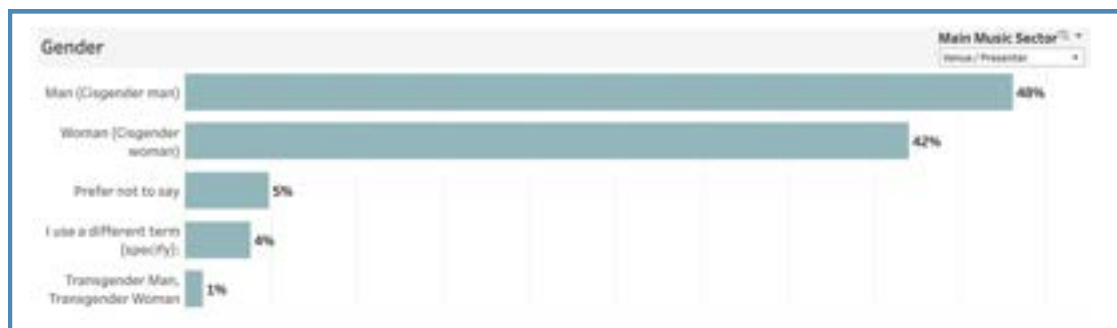


- Race & Ethnicity** - The racial and ethnic composition shows that 55% of participants identify as White/European origin, which is higher than the 42% representation in the general DC area population. Black or African American individuals constitute 25%, closely matching the 24% in the DC area. Participants of two or more races account for 7% versus 5% in the DC area, while Hispanic (4% vs. 17%) and Asian or Asian American (8% vs. 11%) individuals are underrepresented compared to the general population. Native American or Alaskan Native representation is minimal at 1% in the music census.
- Age** - The age distribution of participants shows a strong concentration in the 25 to 54 years range, with 39% aged 25 to 39 years and 32% aged 40 to 54 years. Younger participants (18 to 24 years) account for 6%, while older age groups (55 to 64 years and 65+ years) make up 13% and 9%, respectively.
- Experience** - The experience level within the music ecosystem shows a significant majority with over 10 years of experience, accounting for 76% of participants. Those with 6 to 10 years of experience represent 9%, 3 to 5 years make up 8%, and less than 3 years constitute 6%.



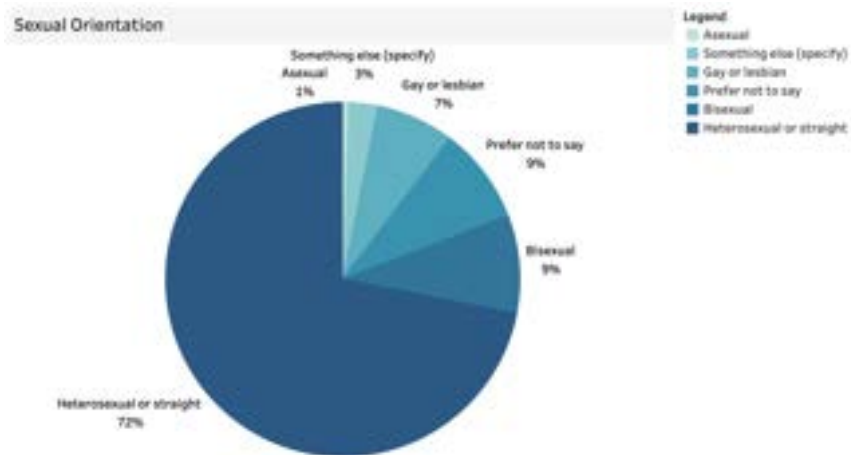
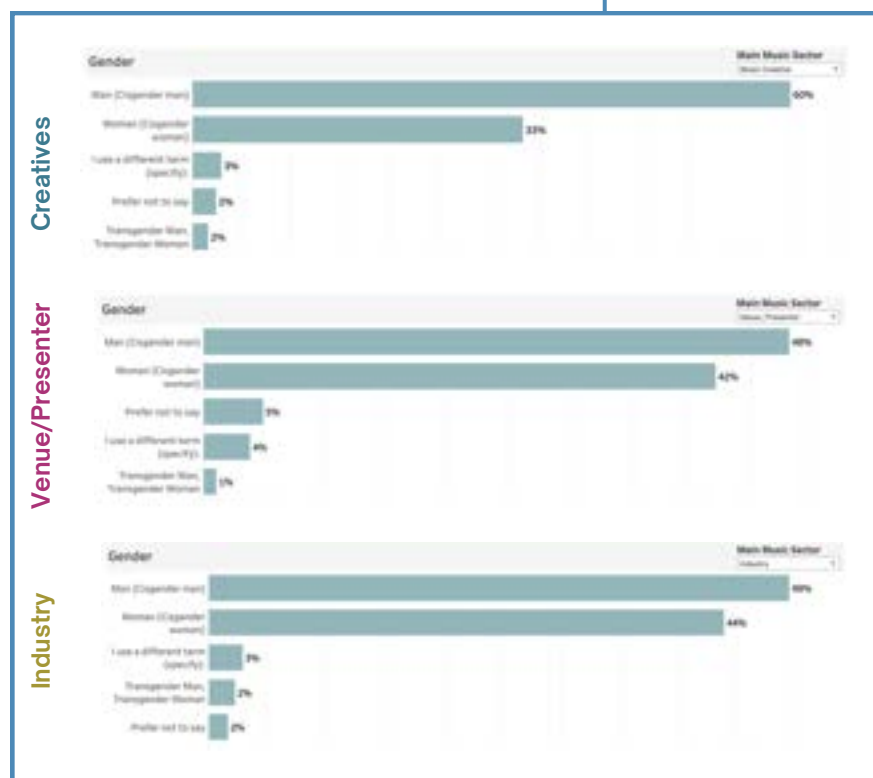
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition (continued 2/3)



- **Gender** - The gender distribution among participants reveals that 58% identify as cisgender men and 35% as cisgender women. A smaller proportion of respondents, 3%, use a different term to describe their gender, 2% prefer not to say, and another 2% identify as transgender men or transgender women

- **Sexual Orientation** - The DC music ecosystem displays a diverse range of sexual orientations among its respondents. The majority, 72%, identify as heterosexual or straight. Bisexual individuals make up 9% of the respondents, indicating a notable presence within the community. Those who identify as gay or lesbian represent 7%, Asexual 1%, and 3% identify as something else not specified. Meanwhile, 9% of respondents prefer not to disclose their sexual orientation.



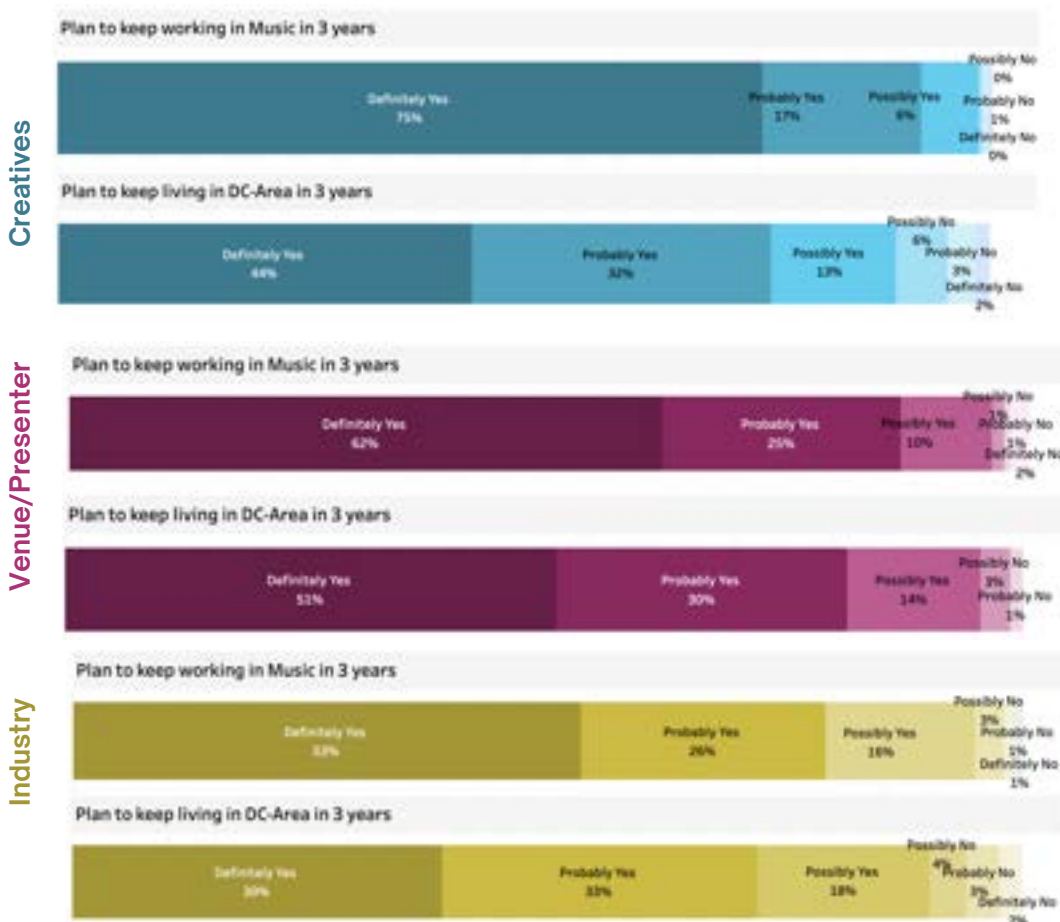
Most people in the scene are very kind and open to meeting new people! There's a wide range of musical diversity in the area and you can almost always find what you're looking for, and somewhere to play or listen to it.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition (continued 3/3)

Plans to Stay in Music and in the Washington DC-Area

- **Creatives** - The majority of Creative respondents in the DC music ecosystem (92%) are confident about continuing to work in music over the next three years, with a strong 75% responding "Definitely Yes." However, there is slightly less certainty about staying in the DC-area, as 76% responded "Definitely Yes" or "Probably Yes" to living in the DC-area in three years.
- **Venue/Presenter** - The majority of Venue/Presenter respondents in the DC music ecosystem (87%) are confident about continuing to work in music over the next three years. Those confident about staying in the DC-area in three years drops only slightly to 81%. This indicates a strong professional commitment to the music industry and to staying in the DC-area.
- **Industry** - The majority of Industry respondents in the DC music ecosystem (79%) are confident about continuing to work in music over the next three years as well as staying in the DC-area (72%).



“The local ecosystem pretends to be inclusive and diverse however most of the scene is divided into smaller sub-communities that really aren't as open to inclusion as it portrays itself to be.”

“The DC music scene is an extremely welcoming and safe space for LGBTQ musicians.”

“The music scene is rich in culture and true to the sound of DC and its inhabitants.”

“The most frustrating aspect of the local ecosystem is our inability to get organized to demand larger scale public support for the arts.”

“The DC Experimental scene is amazing. Excellent, open, inclusive group of people trying to support each other and make space for new acts.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile

In the DC-area music scene, 81% of Music Creative respondents have over 10 years of experience. Their primary income sources are local live performances (33%), teaching (17%), and touring (24%), but many earn little to no income from recordings, songwriting, studio work, and merchandise. Key career concerns include the rising cost of living (43%), stagnant pay rates (33%), and lack of music work (27%), with additional worries about limited time for creativity (21%) and increasing music-related expenses (15%). Creative respondents in the DC-area spend an average of \$7,969 annually on music-related expenses, 50% of which stays local for an annual spend collectively of \$17M.

- Sources of Income** - Creative respondents in the DC-area derive their income from various sources, with local live performances being the most significant (33% receive 'some' income from this). Teaching (17%) and live performance touring (24%) also contribute notably to their income. However, many creatives report very little or no income from recordings (44% none), songwriting (59% none), studio work (57% none), and merchandise (59% none).

“I love the DC music scene. It often uplifts people and is very collaborative. The scene has a degree of competition but not overly so; bands largely hype each other up.”

Creative: Sources of Income



- Career Concerns** - The primary career concerns for Creative respondents in the DC-area music scene include the increasing cost of living (43% highest concern), pay rates not increasing (33% highest concern), and the lack of music work (27% highest concern). Additionally, 21% of participants expressed that they lack time for creativity, and 15% are worried about increasing music-related expenses.

Creative Career Concerns



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile (continued 2/3)

- **Spend** - Creative respondents in the DC-area spend an average of \$7,969 annually on music-related expenses, highlighting an investment in their careers. The breakdown indicates that the highest costs are for rehearsal or workspace and recording, averaging \$1,671 and \$1,581 respectively. Annually, gear rentals expenses account for \$1,576, supplies run \$1,135, and promotional activities cost \$1,093. This spending, especially keeping 50% local, underscores the critical role of DC-area Creatives in bolstering the local economy through their financial commitments to various services and products provided by local industry.

Creative Expenses Annually - Average



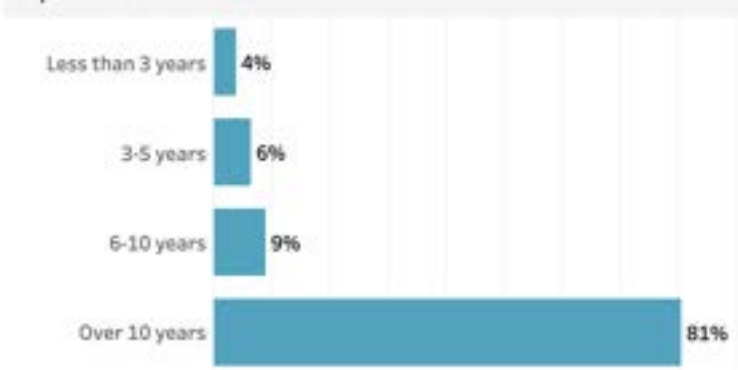
\$7,969
Average Creative Spend

\$17M
Total Creative Respondents Spend Annually

50%
Spent Locally

- **Experience** - Creative respondents in the DC-area music scene show a significant majority with over 10 years of experience, accounting for 81% of participants. Those with 6 to 10 years of experience represent 9%, 3 to 5 years make up 6%, and less than 3 years constitute 4%.

Experience - Creatives



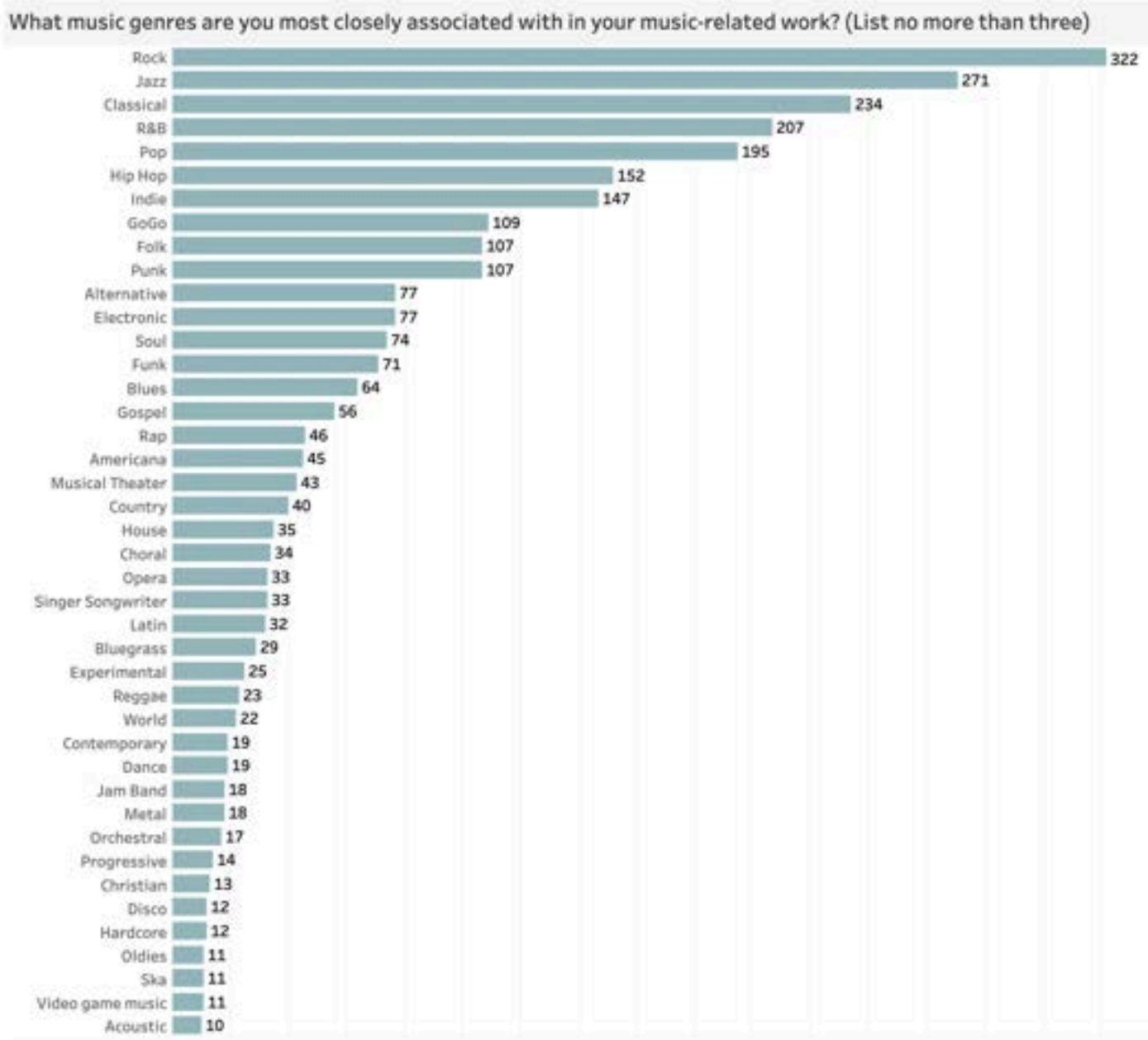
There's a lot of room for different styles, genres, and expressions. The collaborative and supportive environment in DC is inspiring and thriving.

It's difficult for new or less connected bands to find shows and have their music featured in local media. It's hard to find out who is even booking at which venues.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile (continued 3/3)

- **Genre Representation** - The DC-area enjoys a very diverse range of musical genres. Rock is the most common genre, associated with 322 respondents, followed by Jazz (271), Classical (234), R&B (207), and Pop (195). Other notable genres include Hip Hop (152), Indie (147), and GoGo (109). Less common genres include Experimental (25), Reggae (23), World (22), and Acoustic, which is the least represented at 10 respondents.



“ I enjoy the diversity of music genres in DC. I work in several genres and encourage more cross-collaboration with other artists. ”

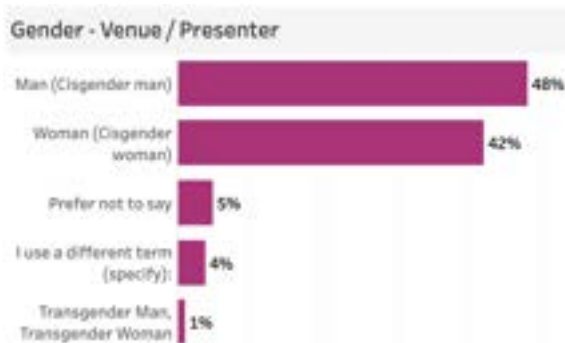
“ As an artist that mixes genres, it's hard to get booked because the scene here is segregated and rigid. I can't get booked at rock venues because I incorporate rap and vice versa. ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile

Venue/Presenter respondents show a gender distribution of 48% men and 42% women, with some preferring not to disclose or using different terms. Ownership is predominantly for-profit (47%), with significant nonprofit (36%) and informal setups (11%). Live music venues (24%) are the most common, followed by festivals (15%) and independent promoters (12%). Venue capacities vary widely, with most accommodating 1-200 people, and 69% offering outdoor capabilities. Respondents host an average of 95 live events annually, contributing to a total of 13,567 live events each year.

- **Venue/Presenter Type** - Live music venues are the most common type of venue, representing 24% of the total. Festivals account for 15%, and various independent promoters make up 12%. Other notable types include house/DIY/private venues (6%), community spaces (5%), bars (5%), and event spaces for rent (4%).



Venues average

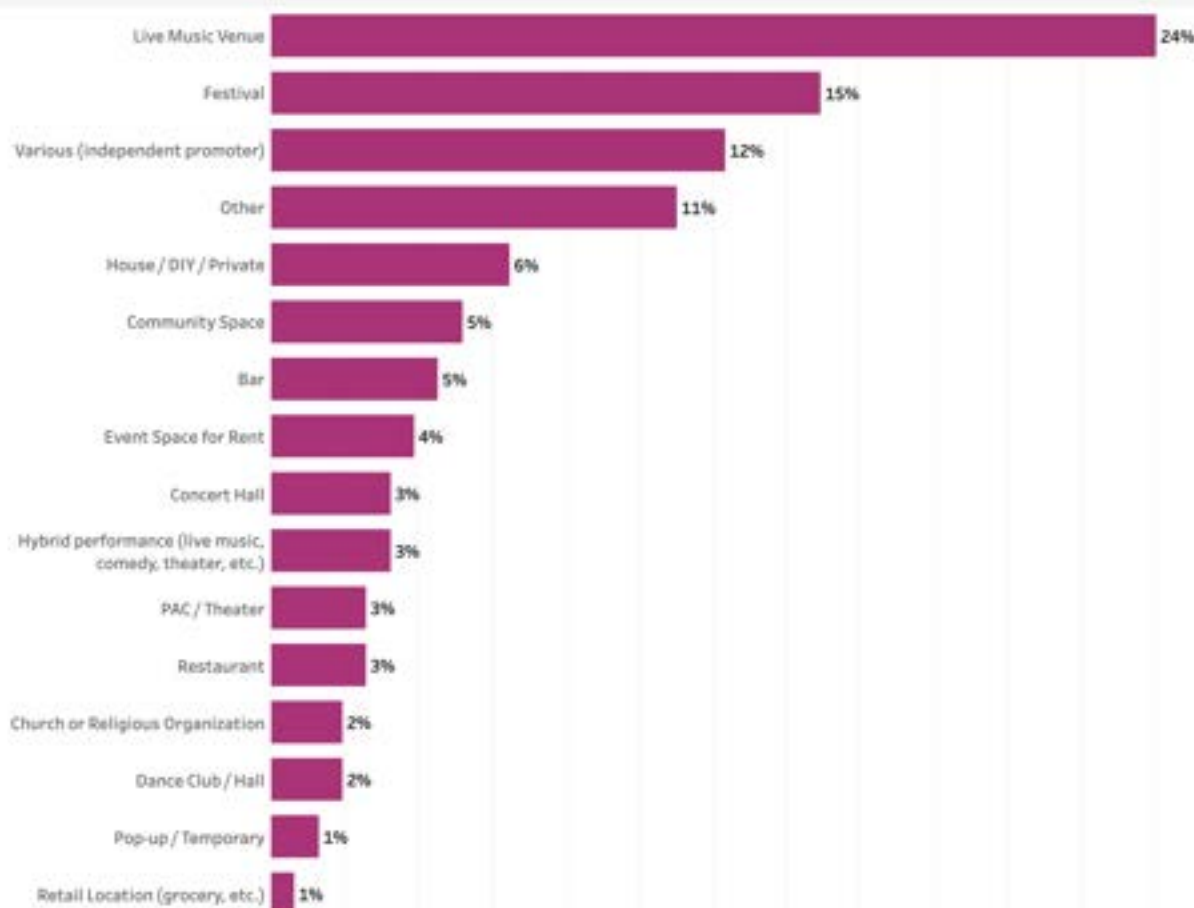
95

live events/year

13,567

total live events/year

Venue/Presenter Type



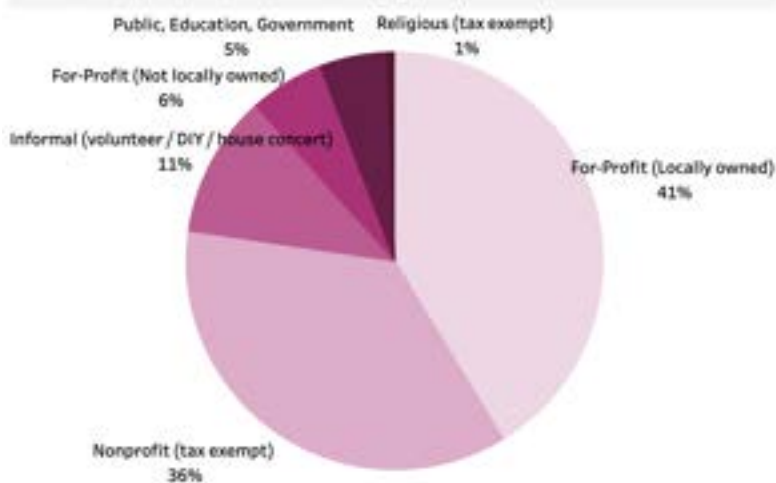
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile (continued)

• Venue Ownership/Tax Structure

The ownership structure of Venues/Presenters is predominantly for-profit, with 41% being locally owned and 6% not locally owned. Nonprofit organizations make up 36% of the total, followed by informal setups such as volunteer, DIY, or house concerts at 11%. Other ownership types include public, education, government at 5%, and religious (tax exempt) at 1%.

Venue/Presenter Ownership (Tax) Structure



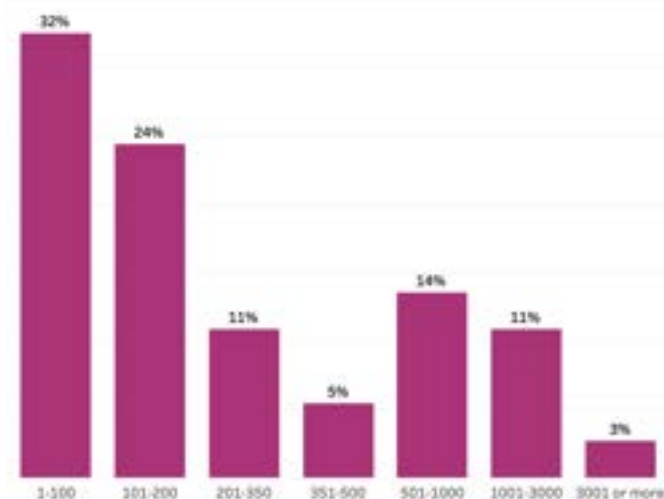
“ I love the vibrant atmosphere that local venues create. They bring people together and foster a sense of community that is hard to find elsewhere. ”

“ Our local venues are incredibly supportive of emerging artists. They provide a platform for new talent to be discovered and appreciated. ”

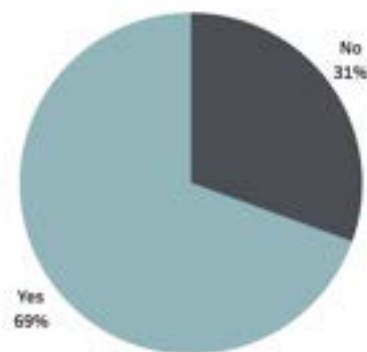
“ The quality of events hosted at our venues is top-notch. The sound systems are excellent, and the overall experience is always memorable. ”

- **Venue Capacity & Outdoor Capabilities** - Venue capacities ranges widely, with the largest group having a capacity of 1-100 people, accounting for 32% of venues. This is followed by venues with a capacity of 101-200 people, making up 24%. Smaller percentages of venues can accommodate larger crowds, with 14% having a capacity of 501-1000 people, 11% each for capacities of 201-350 and 1001-3000 people, 5% for 351-500 people, and only 3% for 3001 or more people. Additionally, 69% of venues have outdoor capabilities, while 31% do not.

Venue Capacity - Owner



Outdoor Capabilities



“ We desperately need more venues that are accessible and affordable. The current options are too limited and often too expensive for emerging artists. ”

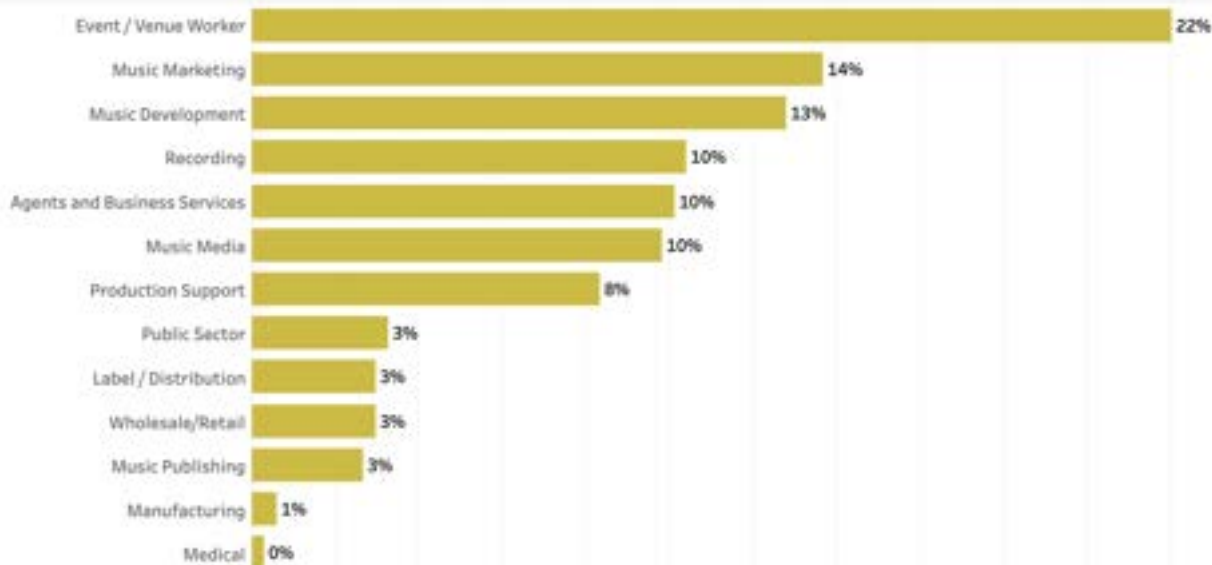
“ The high costs associated with booking and performing at existing venues are a significant barrier. More affordable options are necessary to support the local music scene. ”

“ Venues need to be more supportive of emerging artists. Flexible booking policies and better promotion of new talent would make a big difference. ”

Industry Profile

The DC-area Music Industry supports a strong reliance on locally sourced services from Creatives, with 46% using local studios, 36% local equipment, and 28% local legal/accounting services. Many Creative professionals handle management (69%), booking (69%), and publicity/social media (79%) on their own. Event/venue workers make up the largest group in the Industry sector at 22%, followed by music marketing (14%) and development (13%). DC-area Industry serves primarily local clients. Across the majority of the Industry client base, 68% are local, 32% are national, and 9% are international.

Industry Current Occupation



- **Industry Occupation** - Within the music industry, the largest group of professionals are event/venue workers (22%), followed by music marketing (14%) and music development (13%). Other notable roles include recording, agents and business services, and music media, each making up 10% of the respondents. Smaller segments include production support (8%), public sector, label/distribution, wholesale/retail, and music publishing, each at 3%. The least represented roles are manufacturing and medical, at 1% and 0%, respectively.

“The collaborative nature of the music community is a standout aspect. There's a strong network of support among industry professionals.”

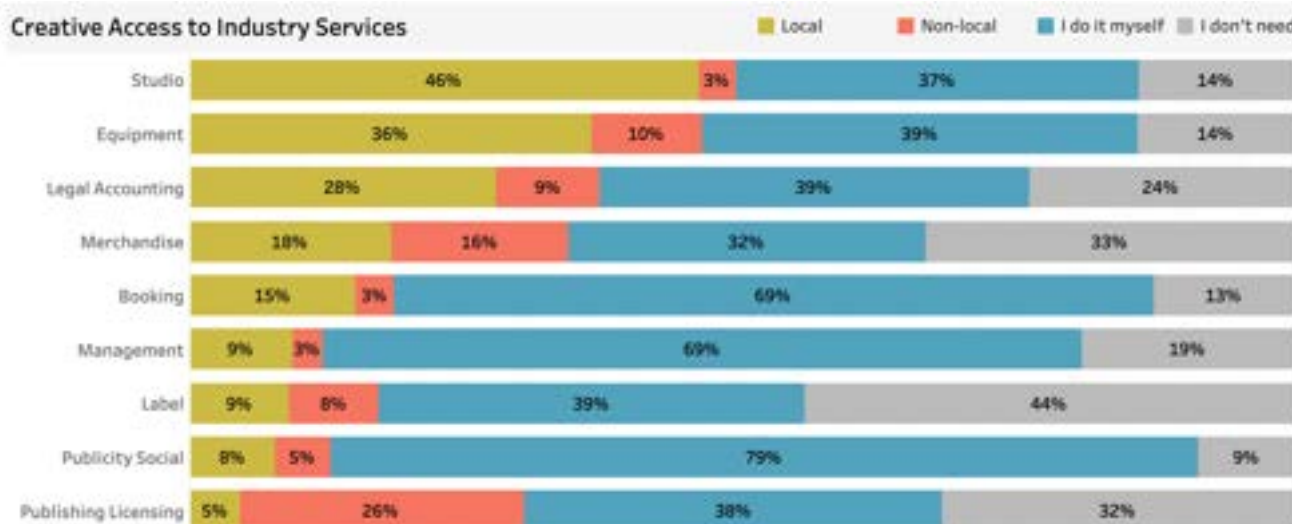
“The diversity in music genres and opportunities for cross-genre collaboration make our industry vibrant and dynamic.”

“There is a need for better communication and collaboration between different sectors of the music industry to streamline processes and reduce inefficiencies.”

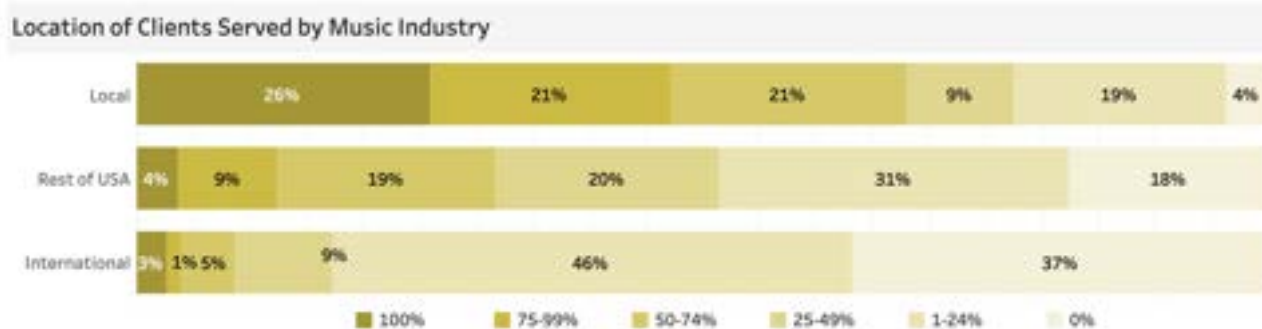
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Industry Profile (continued)

- **Creative Access to Industry** - A significant portion of music industry services are sourced locally by DC-area Creatives, particularly studios (46%), equipment (36%), and legal/accounting (28%). However, many Creative professionals handle industry services like management (69%), booking (69%), and publicity/social media (79%) on their own. Non-local services are less commonly used, with the highest being legal/accounting (9%) and merchandise (16%). Some respondents indicate they do not require certain services, especially labels (44%), merchandise (33%), and management (19%).



- **Location of Clients** - DC-area Industry is serving primarily local clients. Across the majority of the Industry client base, 68% are local, 32% are national, and 9% are international. This highlights a mix of strong local focus and significant national as well as small international engagement.



“The lack of sector-wide collaboration often results in duplicated efforts and missed opportunities for growth and innovation within the industry.”

“More collaborative initiatives and partnerships are required to support emerging artists and provide them with the resources they need to succeed.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity

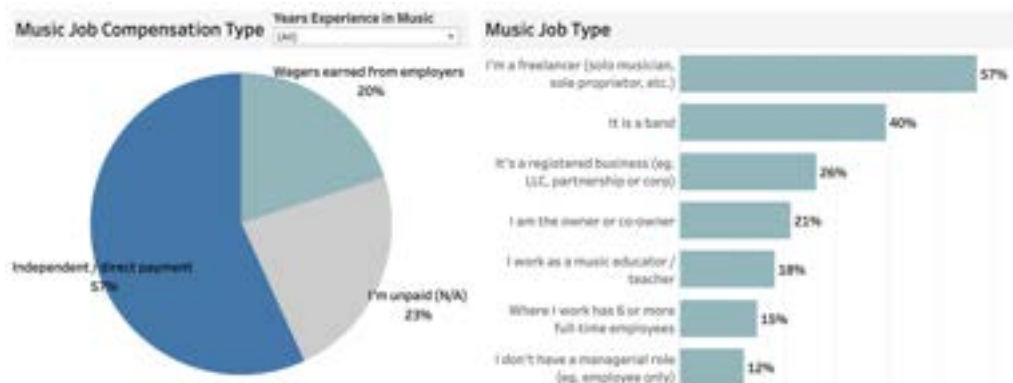
Music significantly contributes to the economy of the DC-area, generating \$63 million annually. It accounts for 22% of respondents' income, averaging \$23,000 per year. Most respondents (57%) receive independent or direct payment, while 23% are unpaid and 20% earn wages from employers. Many identify as freelancers (57%) or band members (40%), with some operating registered businesses (26%) and working as educators (18%). Performance frequency varies, with many lacking local paid gigs and a disparity in pay between local (\$446) and touring performances (\$136). About 45% of respondents are IP rights holders, using various royalty collection and licensing methods. Venues host an average of 95 live events per year, focusing on local talent. Additionally, 68% work outside of music, with 88% relying on their external job for primary income, highlighting the economic challenges in the music industry.

Music generates a total of **\$63M** in income annually across all respondents

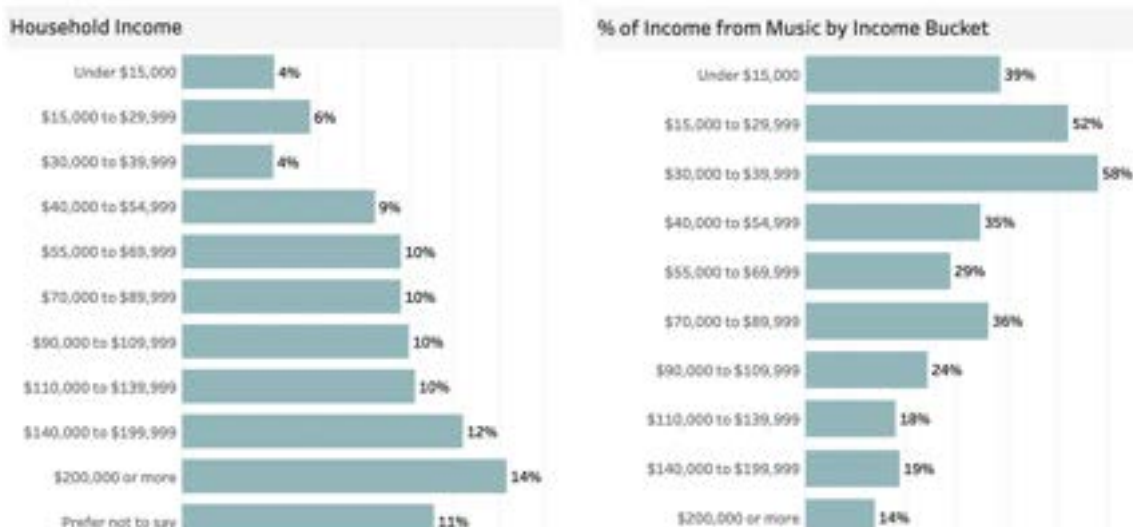
22% of respondent annual income comes from music

Average household income for respondents is **\$106K**

Average annual income from music is **\$23K/respondent**



- **Music Job Type/Compensation** - A majority of respondents in the DC-area music ecosystem, 57%, receive independent or direct payment for their work, while 23% are unpaid, and only 20% earn wages from employers. Regarding music job types, 57% identify as freelancers, 40% are in bands, and 26% operate registered businesses. Additionally, 21% are owners or co-owners, 18% work as music educators or teachers, and 15% work in environments with six or more full-time employees. These data underscore a strong trend towards independent work and varied roles within the local music industry.

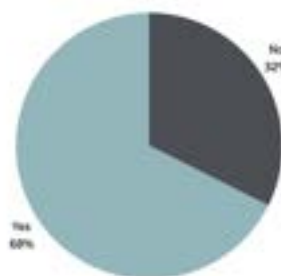


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

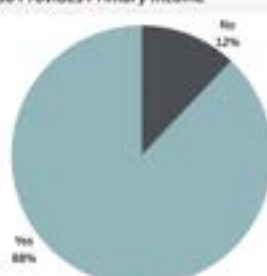
Economic Activity (continued 2/3)

- **Work Outside Music** - In the DC-area music ecosystem, 68% of respondents work outside of music, with 88% of these individuals indicating that their outside job provides their primary income. This highlights that a significant majority of music professionals rely on external employment to sustain their livelihoods, underscoring the challenges of making a full-time living within the music sector alone.

Work Outside of Music



For those who work outside of music,
Outside Job Provides Primary Income

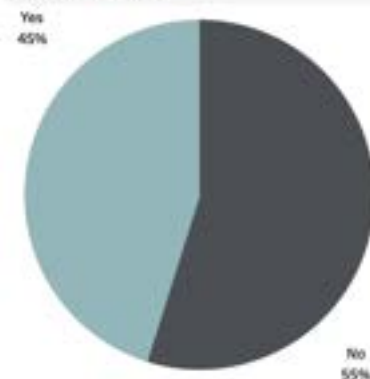


“Most people in the music scene have to have a job that is separate from performing that provides the majority of their income.”

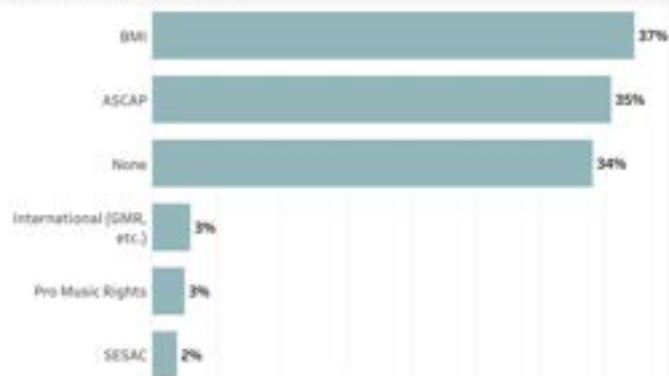
Outside Work Motivation



IP Rightsholder



Royalty Collection Methods



Licensing



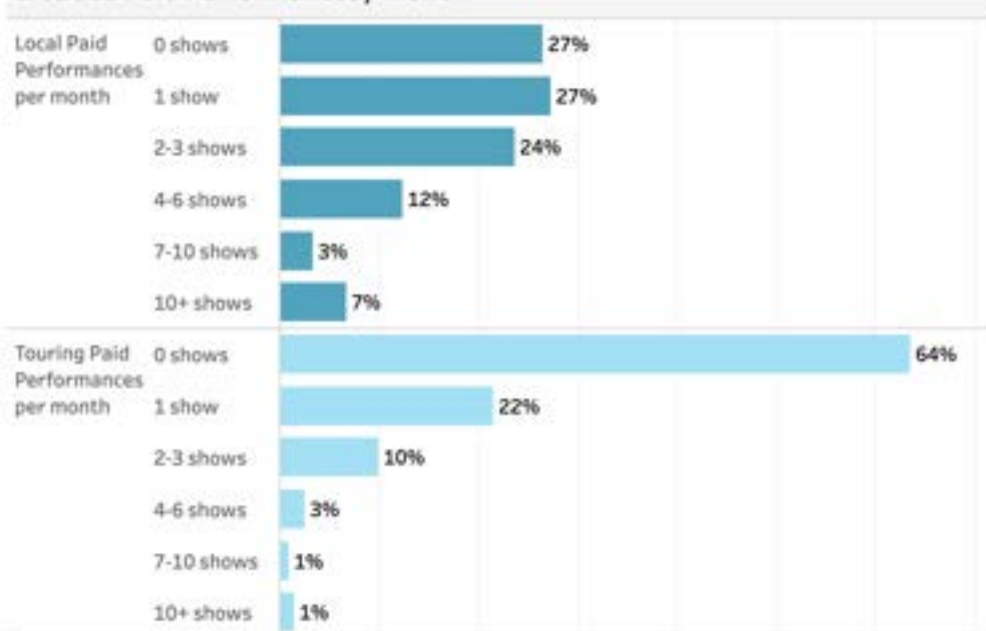
- **Publishing/Licensing** - In the DC-area music ecosystem, 45% of respondents are IP rights holders, while 55% are not. Among those who collect royalties, 37% use BMI, 35% use ASCAP, and 34% do not collect royalties at all. Other collection methods include international organizations (3%), Pro Music Rights (3%), and SESAC (2%). Regarding licensing, 46% do not engage in licensing activities, 25% have a provider handle it, 21% work with a publisher or rights admin, and 18% rely on their record label or sync representative for licensing management. These data highlight a varied approach to royalty collection and licensing within the local music industry.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity (continued 3/3)

- Creative Performance Frequency & Pay** - A significant portion of creative respondents, 27%, do not have any local paid performances per month, while another 27% perform locally once a month, and 24% perform 2-3 times per month. Only a small percentage, 7%, perform more than 10 shows locally each month. For touring performances, 64% do not perform at all, while 22% perform once a month. The average pay per gig is notably higher for local performances at \$446 compared to \$136 for touring performances, highlighting a substantial disparity in earnings between local and touring engagements. However, when we look at the median pay, we see \$150/local gig and \$100/touring gig.

Creative Paid Performances / Month



\$446

average pay/local gig

\$136

average pay/touring gig

\$150

median pay/local gig

\$100

median pay/touring gig

“The financial flow feels slow or stagnant at times.”

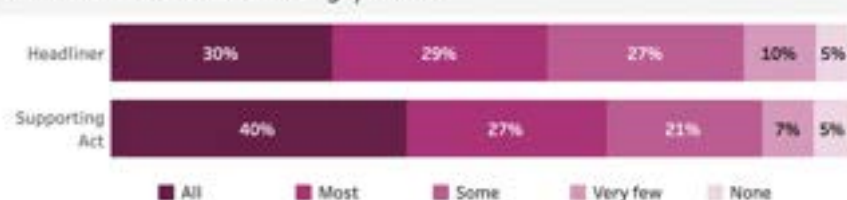
“Making it somewhat more financially sustainable for venues to exist would be helpful, so that more venues would be created and flourish.”

“Gig pay having not gone up when housing has inflated so much. The difficulty owning a house as a musician.”

“It is very hard to earn a living wage and still have time and energy to do music because we are paid next to nothing.”

- Venue Live Events and Local Talent Bookings** - On average, Venues in the DC area host 95 live events per year, totaling 13,567 events. When it comes to booking local talent, 30% of headliners and 40% of supporting acts are local artists for all their shows. Additionally, 29% of venues book local headliners for most shows, while 27% book them for some shows. The figures for supporting acts are similar, with 27% booking local talent for most shows and 21% for some shows. Only a small fraction of venues rarely or never book local talent as headliners or supporting acts.

Presenters Local Talent Bookings / Month



Venues average

95

live events/year

13,567

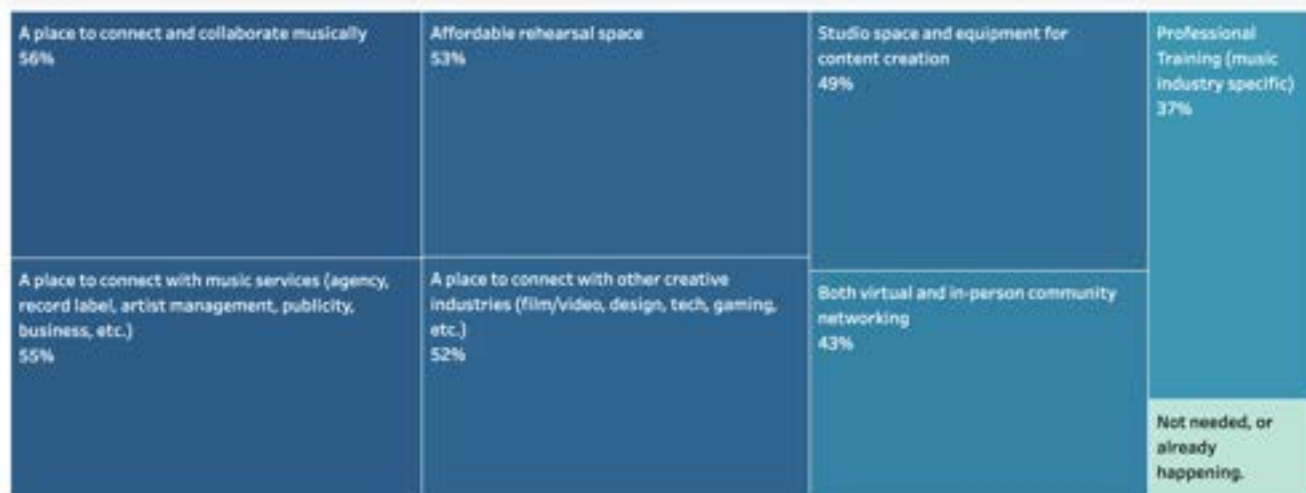
total live events/year

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development

The DC-area music ecosystem faces significant challenges in commercial workspace availability, with the majority of venues and spaces being rented rather than owned. This rental dependency affects live performance venues (88%), temporary spaces (81%), and manufacturing/repair/retail spaces (72%), making them vulnerable to market trends. There are substantial unmet needs for rehearsal spaces (56%), studios (60%), and storage (81%). Desired resources include collaboration spaces (56%) and affordable rehearsal spaces (53%), alongside studio space, music service connections, and industry-specific training. Venues and presenters prioritize business resources to boost audience development (79%) and support for local music scene infrastructure. Financial assistance is limited, with only 22% of respondents having received aid, primarily from personal networks, grants, and subsidies. The primary locations for music-related work are concentrated in Northwest DC (73%), highlighting regional activity hubs within the metro area.

Local Music Resource Preference



Local Music Resource Preferences

- 56% seek spaces for musical collaboration
- 55% desire a place to connect with music industry services
- 53% want affordable rehearsal space overall, however DC resident respondents rank this highest at 61%
- 52% want to connect with other creative industries like film, design, and tech

“Lack of affordable rehearsal space for orchestra, especially those at the startup phase with little funds. Need more financial support or free or low-cost spaces for startups. Need more ways to network with people in similar spaces and related creative like videographers, graphic designers, etc.”

“It’s frustrating that there’s never been a union or some entity to offer health insurance, low-cost loans, financial assistance, a death benefit.”

“Need more venues to play with decent support and sound.”

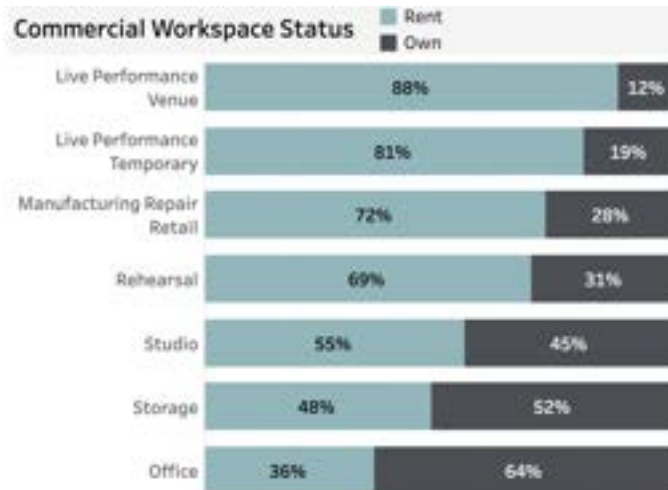
“We need affordable learning and performance opportunities for aspiring musicians.”

“More connects and meetups.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

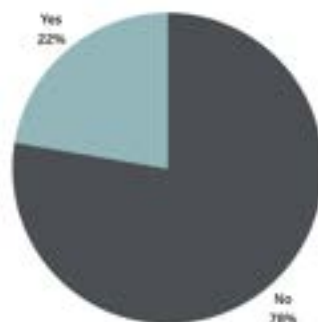
Ecosystem Development (continued 2/3)

- Commercial Workspace Status-** The majority of commercial workspaces are rented rather than owned, including live performance venues (88%), temporary live performance spaces (81%), and manufacturing/repair/retail spaces (72%). Rehearsal spaces (69%) and studios (55%) also see high rental rates. When it comes to needs, 48% of respondents require but do not have a live performance venue, while 56% need rehearsal space, and 60% need studio and temporary live performance spaces. A significant portion of respondents also express a need for manufacturing/repair/retail space (81%) and storage (81%), indicating substantial gaps in available commercial workspace resources for the local music industry.

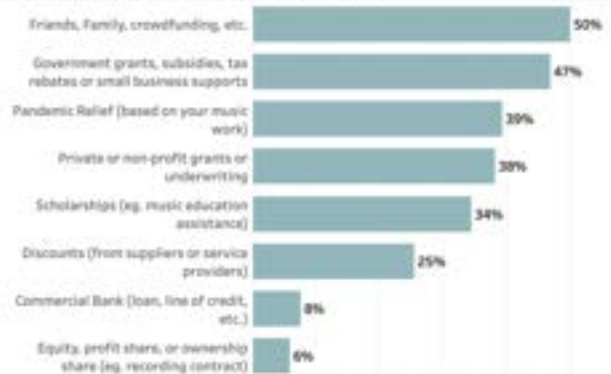


- Financial Support** - Only 22% of respondents have received financial assistance for their music work, while 78% have not. The most common sources of financial assistance include friends, family, and crowdfunding (50%), government grants and subsidies (47%), and pandemic relief funds (39%). Additionally, 38% have received private or non-profit grants, 34% have benefited from scholarships, and 25% have obtained discounts from suppliers or service providers. 56% weren't aware of opportunities. 61% prefer micro-grants and 55% would like tax breaks of any sort.

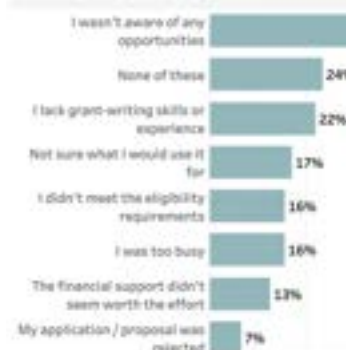
History of Financial Assistance for Music Work



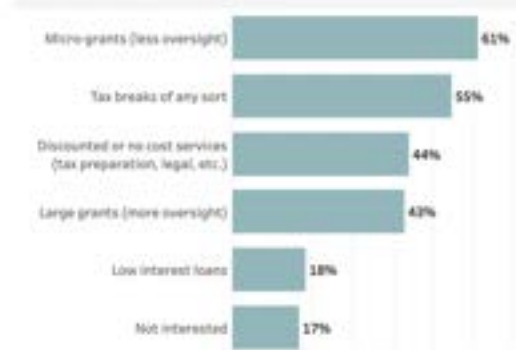
Type of Financial Assistance for Music Work



Financial Assistance Barrier



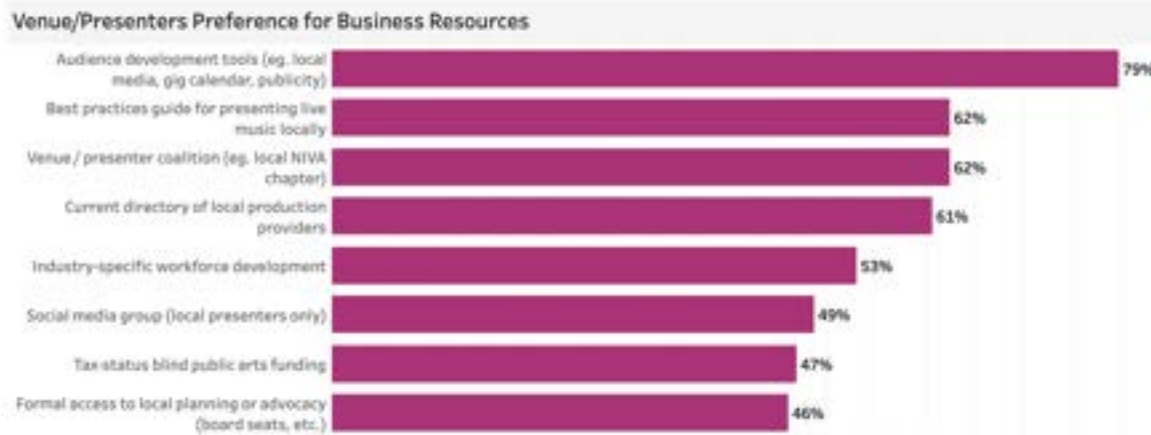
Financial Assistance Preference



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

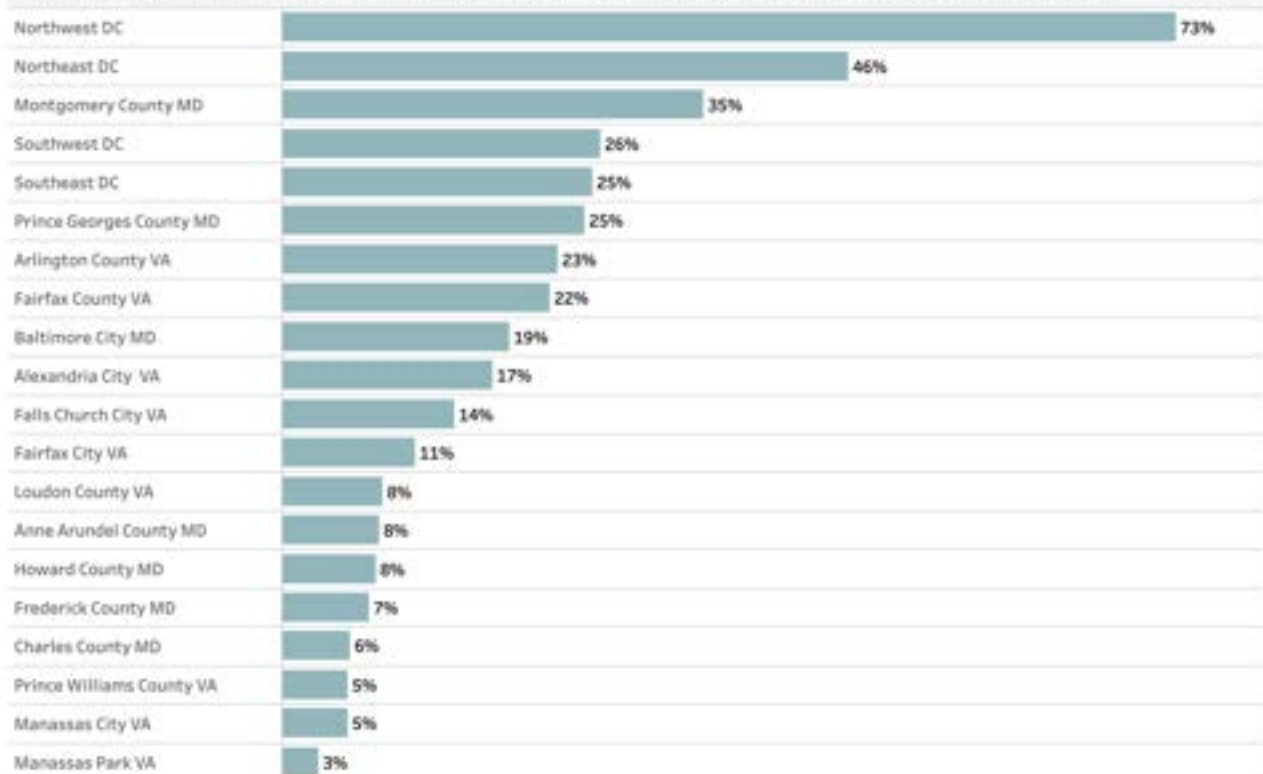
Ecosystem Development (continued 3/3)

- **Venue/Presenter Business Resources** - Venues/Presenters express a strong preference for business resources that enhance audience development (79%), including local media, gig calendars, and publicity tools. They also value best practices guides for presenting live music locally (62%), forming coalitions like local NIVA chapters (62%), and having a current directory of local production providers (61%). Additionally, industry-specific workforce development (53%), social media groups for local presenters (49%), tax-status blind public arts funding (47%), and formal access to local planning or advocacy boards (46%) are important resources for supporting the local music scene.



- **Primary Locations for Music-Related Work in the DC-area** - A majority of respondents (73%) primarily conduct their music-related work in Northwest DC, followed by 46% in Northeast DC, and 35% in Montgomery County, MD. These data highlight the concentration of music-related activities within specific regions of the DC metro area. For Dc resident respondents, Southwest DC and Southeast DC jump up above Montgomery County.

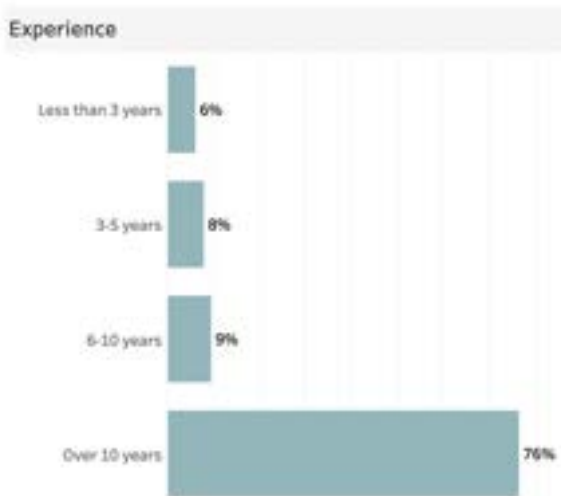
Where does your music-related work/business primarily take place? (For example, where do you perform, practice, book, produce shows or events, provide music-related services, etc.) Choose all of the regions that apply.



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

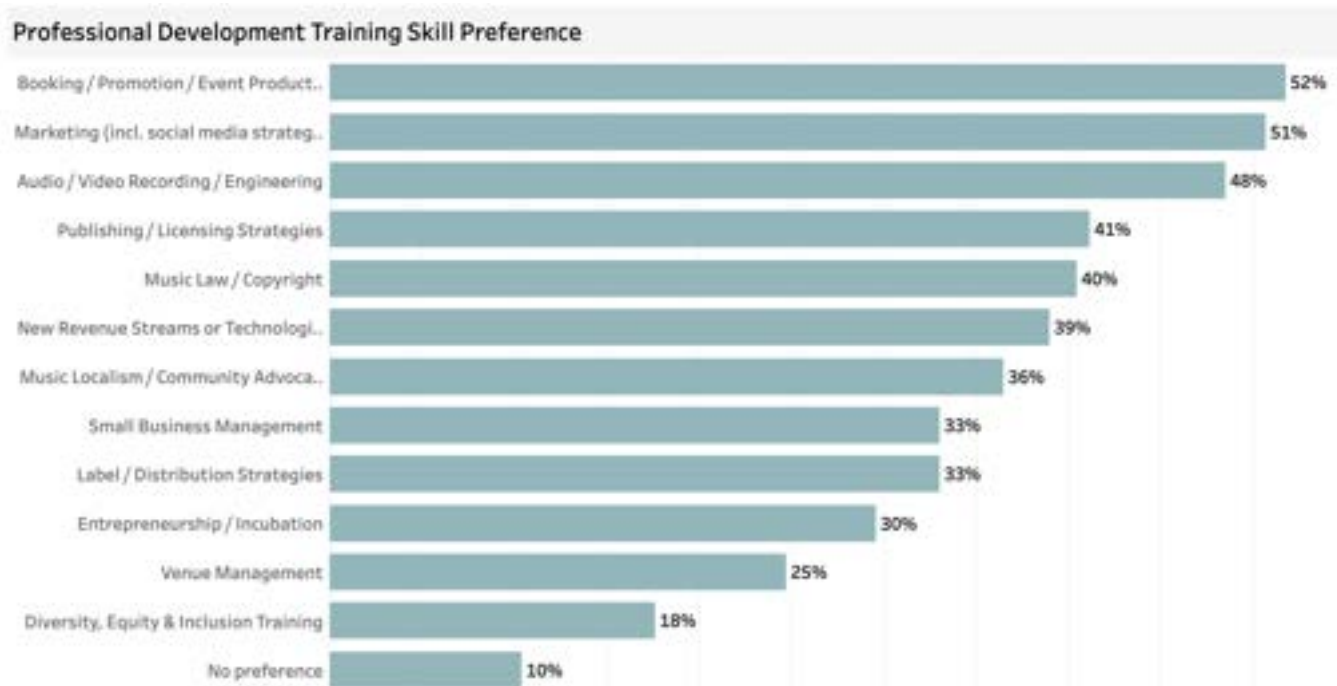
Workforce Development

The DC-area music sector features a highly seasoned workforce, with 76% of respondents having over 10 years of experience. Despite this extensive experience, 61% of music professionals lack memberships or registrations in industry organizations, while 24% are affiliated with royalty collection and music licensing organizations. For professional development, booking, promotion, and event production are the top training preferences, chosen by 52% of respondents, followed closely by marketing at 51% and audio/video recording at 48%.



The lack of industry presence in the area limits the amount of opportunities available to pursue a professional career.

- **Professional Development** - Booking, promotion, and event production is the top professional development training preference, chosen by 52% of respondents. Marketing, including social media strategies, follows closely at 51%. Audio/video recording and engineering is preferred by 48%, while publishing and licensing strategies are selected by 41%. Other notable areas include music law/copyright (40%), new revenue streams or technologies (39%), and music localism/community advocacy (36%).

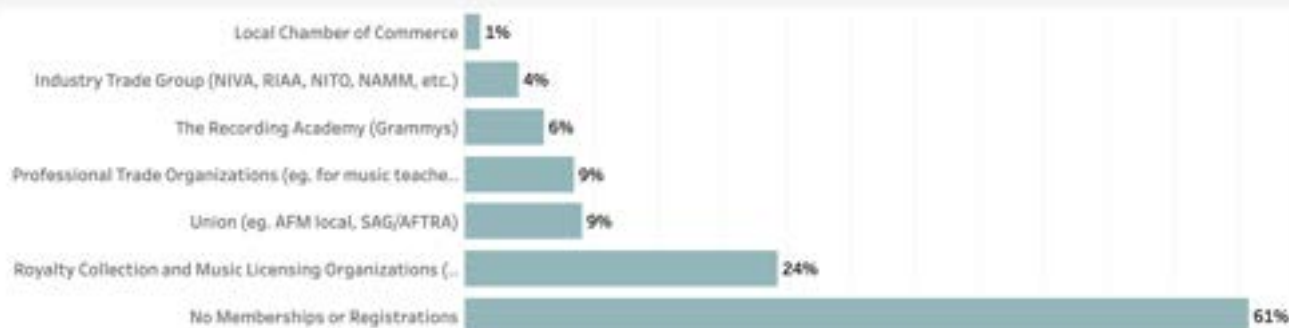


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Workforce Development (continued)

- **Professional Industry Associations** - A significant majority, 61%, of respondents have no memberships or registrations in any organizations. Among those who do, 24% are registered with royalty collection and music licensing organizations, making it the most common affiliation. Professional trade organizations and unions each account for 9%, while 6% are members of The Recording Academy (Grammys). These data indicate a relatively low engagement with industry organizations overall.

Registrations Memberships



More collaboration among local musicians and industry professionals.

The most frustrating thing is being under-employed and underpaid.

Lack of easy access to affordable music training and tutoring.

Affordable music training and opportunities for continuous learning are essential.

Incubators with Coaching, Mentoring programs by age group.

There is a lack of education and access to professional services.

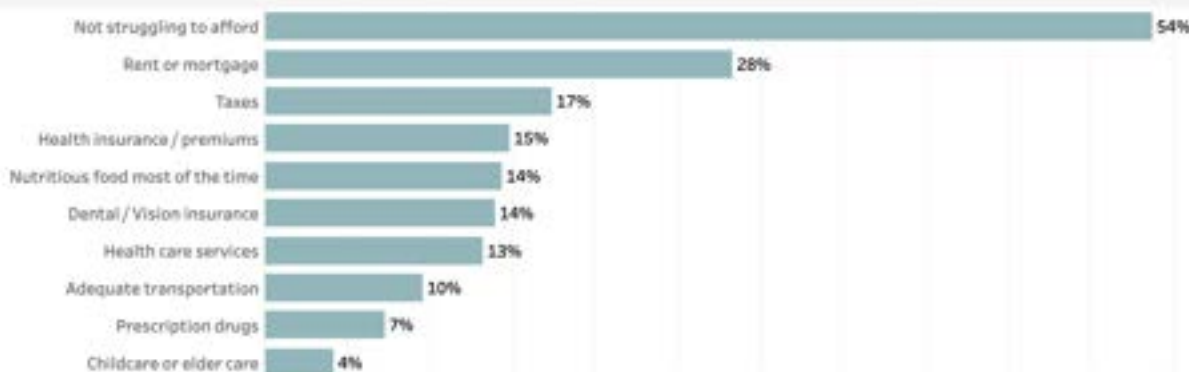
Need more conferences that bring in music professionals to explain how to do different jobs in the music industry.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

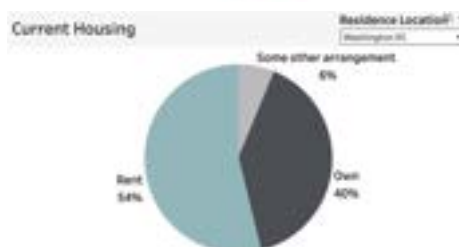
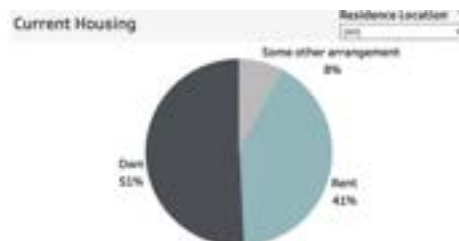
Livability

Over half of survey respondents (54%) are not struggling to afford their basic needs. However, 28% face challenges with rent or mortgage payments, and 17% struggle with taxes. Health insurance premiums (15%) and access to nutritious food (14%) are also significant concerns. Creative professionals are most worried about the increasing cost of living (43%) and stagnant pay rates (33%). Venues and presenters identify talent costs (28%) and competition (18%) as top challenges. Overall, low or uncertain pay (84%) and lack of benefits (68%) are the most pressing issues for those pursuing a music career. 51% own their homes.

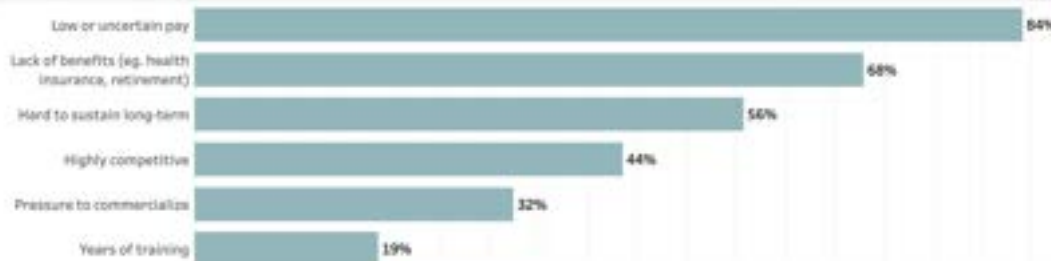
Affordability Struggles



- **Affordability** - Survey respondents express that 54% of them are not struggling to afford their basic needs. However, 28% face difficulties with rent or mortgage payments, and 17% struggle with taxes. Other significant concerns include health insurance premiums (15%), access to nutritious food (14%), dental/vision insurance (14%), healthcare services (13%), and adequate transportation (10%).
- **Housing** - Overall respondents primarily own (51%) their current housing while 41% rent. This flips for DC Resident Respondents where 54% rent their housing and 40% own.
- **Music Career Challenges** - The primary concern among respondents is the increasing cost of living, with 43% ranking it as the highest concern. Pay rates not increasing is also a significant issue for 33% of respondents. Other concerns include a lack of music work (27%), lack of time for creativity (21%), and rising music-related expenses (15%). These issues reflect the financial pressures and constraints on music professionals.



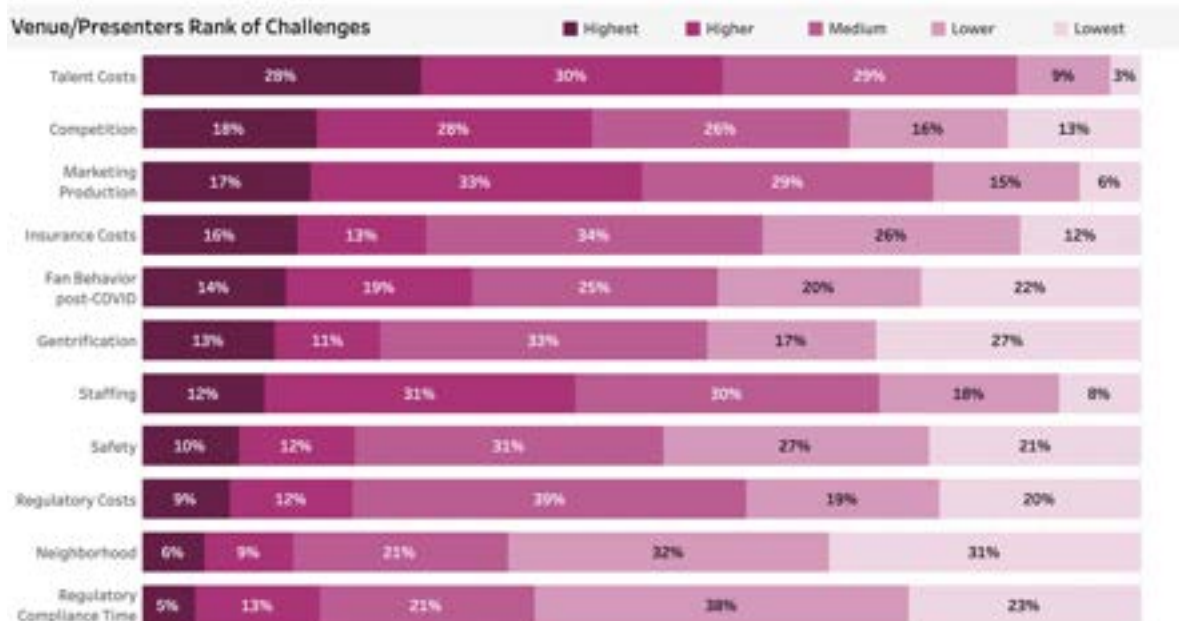
Music Career Challenges



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability (continued)

- **Creative Career Concerns** - The primary concern among Creative respondents is the increasing cost of living, with 43% ranking it as the highest concern. Pay rates not increasing is also a significant issue for 33% of respondents. Other concerns include a lack of music work (27%), lack of time for creativity (21%), and rising music-related expenses (15%). These issues reflect the financial pressures and constraints on creative professionals.
- **Venue/Presenters Rank of Challenges** - The most significant challenges for venues and presenters include talent costs (28%), competition (18%), and marketing/production (17%). Insurance costs (16%), fan behavior post-COVID (14%), gentrification (13%), and staffing (12%) are also notable challenges. Safety (10%), regulatory costs (9%), neighborhood issues (6%), and regulatory compliance time (5%) are considered lower but still relevant concerns.



“Musicians are being priced out of the city due to the high cost of living.”

“The cost-of-living forces musicians to take on multiple jobs, leaving less time for music.”

“Making a living solely from music work is nearly impossible; we have to supplement our income with other jobs.”

“The high cost of living in the DC area makes it nearly impossible to sustain a career in music.”

“High rents are causing performance spaces to close, and affordable rehearsal spaces are hard to find.”

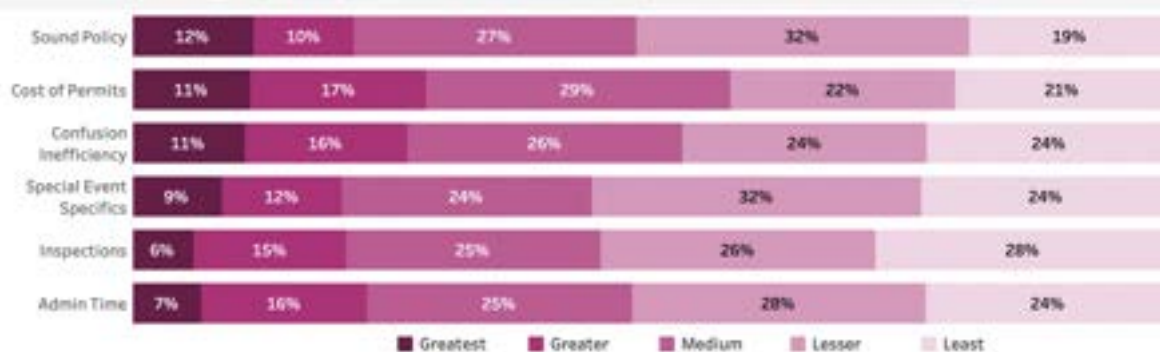
“I've had to move to more affordable areas like Baltimore because rent in DC is too high.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies

Venue/Presenter respondents face significant regulatory challenges, with sound policy (22%) and permit costs (28%) being top concerns, while confusion and inefficiency in processes (27%) also pose issues. They frequently navigate street and parking regulations (64%), insurance requirements (54%), and security/public safety regulations (54%), among other regulatory processes. Financially, 61% of respondents prefer micro-grants with less oversight, while tax breaks (55%) and discounted services (44%) are also favored. To better manage these challenges, Venues and Presenters express a strong preference for regulatory tools like tax discounts (70%), online portals for permitting (69%), and having an advocate inside the government (69%).

Presenters Rank of Regulatory Challenges



- Regulatory Challenges** - Venue/Presenters face several regulatory challenges, with sound policy, cost of permits, and confusion/inefficiency topping the list. Sound policy is considered the greatest challenge by 12% of respondents although 48% rank it high. While 11% rank cost of permits as their top challenge, 62% mark it as a medium-greatest challenge, and similarly 54% feel impacted by confusion/inefficiency with 10% marking it as their top challenge. While only 5% mark it as their top challenge, 42% find inspections a concern, while special event specifics and administrative time each present challenges for 57% and 51% of respondents, respectively.
- Venue/Presenter Tool Preference** - Venues and presenters express a strong preference for various regulatory tools to aid their operations. Tax discounts, waivers, and incentives to host live music are preferred by 70% of respondents. An online portal for permitting and communication, an advocate inside government, and a webpage of current regulations for live music each have 69% support. One point of contact for permitting is favored by 58%, and tiered compliance fees based on the scale or type of presentation are preferred by 43%. Annual training sessions and updates from the regulatory body are supported by 49% of respondents.

Presenters Regulatory Tools Preference

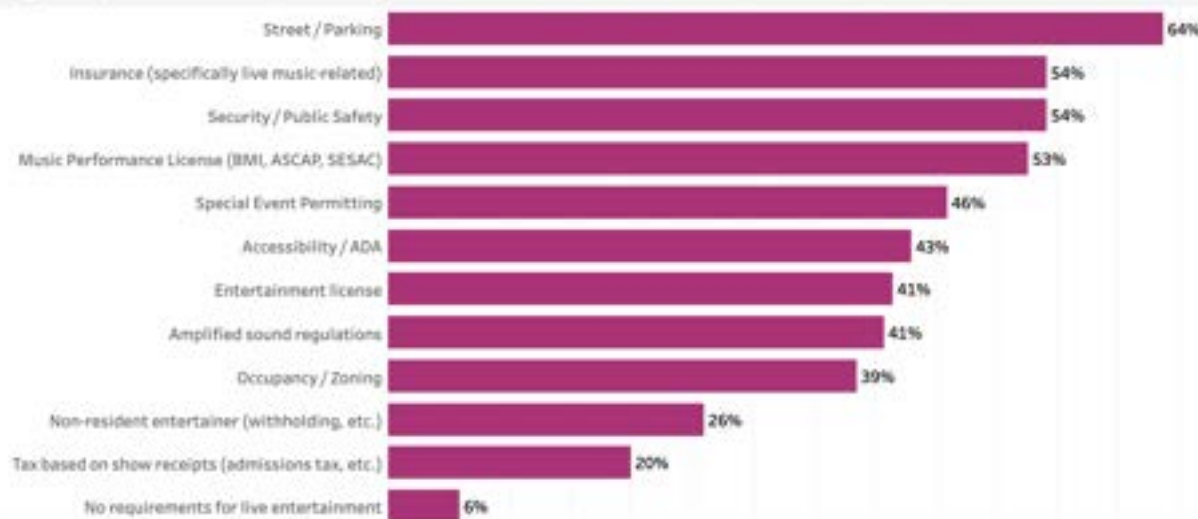
Tax discounts, waivers, incentives to host live music 70%	Online portal for permitting and communication 69%	One point of contact for permitting (vs. separate departments) 58%	Tiered compliance, fees based on scale or type of presentation 43%
An advocate inside government (eg. Office of Nightlife, Creative or Music) 69%	Webpage of current regulations (specifically for live music) 69%	Annual training sessions and updates from regulatory body 49%	

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies (continued)

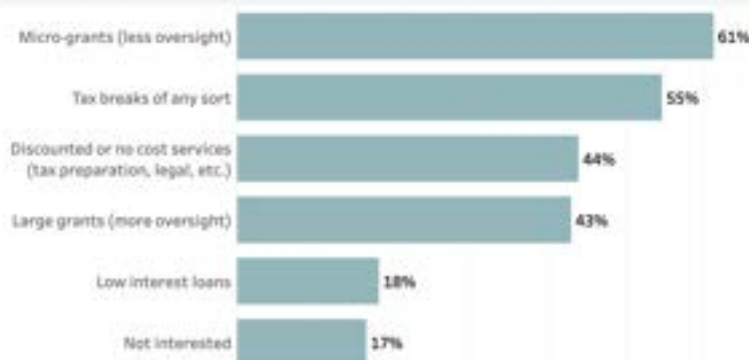
- **Regulatory Fluency** - Venue/Presenters navigate various regulatory processes when hosting live entertainment. The most frequently encountered processes are related to street and parking regulations (64%), followed closely by insurance requirements specifically for live music (54%) and security/public safety regulations (54%). Music performance licenses from organizations like BMI, ASCAP, and SESAC are also commonly dealt with (53%), along with special event permitting (46%). Accessibility and ADA compliance (43%), entertainment licensing (41%), and amplified sound regulations (41%) are other notable processes. Additionally, venues and presenters encounter occupancy/zoning requirements (39%), non-resident entertainer withholding (26%), and tax based on show receipts (20%). A small percentage (6%) report no regulatory requirements for live entertainment.

Regulatory Processes Encountered to Present Live Entertainment



- **Financial Assistance Preferences** - 61% of respondents prefer micro-grants with less oversight. Tax breaks are favored by 55%, and discounted or no-cost services, such as tax preparation and legal assistance, are preferred by 44%. Large grants with more oversight are an option for 43% of respondents. Low-interest loans are less popular, with only 18% indicating interest, and 17% are not interested in financial assistance.

Financial Assistance Preference



“ Noise ordinances are a significant barrier to hosting events, particularly for DIY spaces. These regulations increase the cost of producing shows and limit accessibility for working people. ”

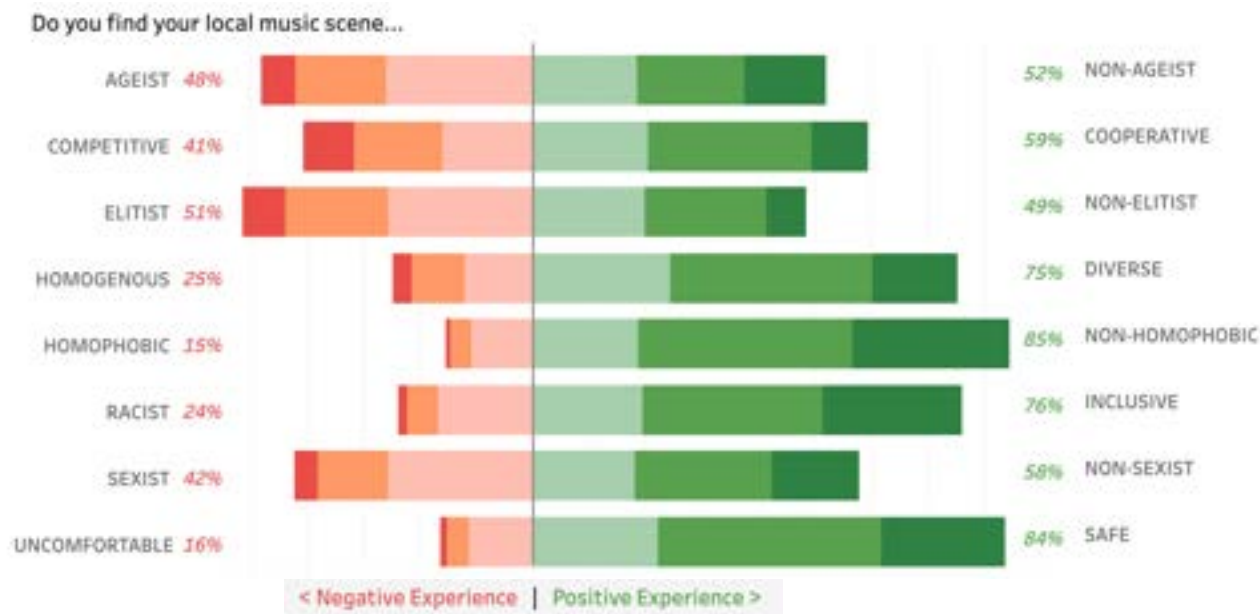
“ There needs to be stricter enforcement of the DC city policy about extra pay for split shifts because they are very common in this industry and rarely paid correctly. ”

“ We need more music business education course offerings. This would greatly improve the professionalism and entrepreneurial acumen of artists in the scene. ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Culture & Belonging

Respondents find that the DC-area music ecosystem offers primarily positive experiences. The DC-area music ecosystem's greatest strengths are that it is non-homophobic (85%), safe (84%), inclusive (76%), and diverse (75%). The DC-area music ecosystem challenges are elitism (51%), ageism (48%), sexism (42%), and competitiveness (41%), highlighting areas for potential improvement despite the overall positive sentiment.



Subgroup Insights

Please see the online dashboard at DCMusicCensus.org for full data on each indicator by subgroup. Some overarching themes to the subgroups are:

- **Negative experiences** - Respondents who experience the most negative (red) side of the DC-area ecosystem are people who identify as Asian or Asian American, those who identify as Black, African or African American, people who identify as Bisexual, as well as those working in Industry.

“Most musical spaces I get invited into as a side-person or collaborator are almost all men, and almost all white people. And yet the scene as a whole is super, super diverse.”

“The local ecosystem pretends to be inclusive and diverse, however, most of the scene is divided into smaller sub-communities that really aren't as open to inclusion as it portrays itself to be.”

“There needs to be more diversity in relation to opportunities and funding for women-led projects and companies.”

“It is very male dominated, and I also think limited opportunities for shows is frustrating.”

“Low pay and lack of opportunities for underrepresented groups.”

“The scene is very male dominated. There have been reports of women being sexually propositioned in order to get performance gigs. I'd like to have this exposed and stopped.”

“The music scene in DC is very male dominated and while it is typically accepting, I've noticed that many artists get pigeonholed because of how they look. The space is also very competitive and elitist as most artists gate keep opportunities.”

Key Insights

Economic Activity and Employment: Music significantly contributes to the local economy, generating substantial income for professionals. However, many respondents (68%) work outside of music to sustain their livelihoods, highlighting the economic challenges within the industry.

Cost of Living: Rising living costs and stagnant pay rates are major concerns for creatives, impacting their economic stability. Many struggle with rent or mortgage payments (28%) and other essential expenses, forcing them to take on multiple jobs.

Performance Opportunities: There is a need for more diverse and affordable performance venues. Many creatives lack local paid gigs, and there is a notable disparity in earnings between local performances (\$446 per gig) and touring (\$136 per gig).

Workforce Experience: The majority of respondents have over 10 years of experience (76%), indicating a seasoned workforce. However, there is a need to attract and nurture new talent to ensure future growth and innovation.

Professional Development Needs: There is strong demand for training in booking, promotion, audio/video recording, and marketing. Improved networking opportunities and access to industry-specific training are crucial for professional growth.

Regulatory Barriers: Venues and presenters face significant challenges with sound policies (22%) and permit costs (28%). Simplified and more efficient regulatory processes are needed to support the local music scene.

Support Structures: Limited access to financial support and a lack of centralized resources for music professionals are significant challenges. Many respondents prefer micro-grants (61%) and tax breaks (55%) as financial assistance.

Diversity and Inclusion: The ecosystem offers positive experiences in terms of diversity and inclusion, with 75% viewing it as diverse and 76% as inclusive. However, issues like elitism (51%) and sexism (42%) highlight areas for improvement.

Music Licensing and Royalty Collection: Many creatives do not engage in licensing activities (46%), indicating potential areas for increased revenue streams. There is varied engagement with royalty collection organizations like BMI (37%) and ASCAP (35%).

Genre Representation: The scene includes diverse genres like Rock, Jazz, Classical, R&B, Hip Hop, and GoGo, contributing to the rich musical culture of DC. Less common genres like Experimental and Reggae also add to the diversity.

Collaboration Spaces and Central Hub: There is a strong need for affordable rehearsal spaces and a central hub for communication and support. Many respondents express unmet needs for commercial workspaces, including rehearsal and studio spaces.

Community and Culture: The DC music scene is perceived as collaborative and supportive, with a strong network of local talent. However, the competitive nature of the scene (41%) and the presence of sub-communities can create barriers to broader inclusivity.

Plans to Stay in Music and DC: A significant majority of creatives (75%) and industry professionals (53%) plan to continue working in music over the next three years. However, fewer respondents are certain about staying in the DC area, especially due to cost of living, indicating potential retention challenges.

Opportunities

Expand Financial Support Programs: Develop more accessible financial assistance programs, such as micro-grants with less oversight and tax breaks, to alleviate economic challenges faced by creatives and venue operators.

Enhance Professional Development: Offer comprehensive training programs in booking, promotion, audio/video recording, and marketing to equip music professionals with essential skills for career advancement.

Simplify Regulatory Processes: Work with local government to streamline and simplify regulatory processes, particularly around sound policies and permit costs, to reduce barriers for venues and presenters.

Increase Affordable Performance Venues: Promote the development of more diverse and affordable performance venues, including smaller and non-bar venues, to provide more opportunities for local musicians.

Support New and Emerging Talent: Implement initiatives to attract and nurture new talent, ensuring a continuous influx of fresh and innovative contributors to the music scene.

Create Centralized Music Hubs: Establish affordable rehearsal spaces and central hubs for communication and support, fostering collaboration and community among music professionals.

Foster Genre Diversity and Collaboration: Encourage cross-genre collaboration and support diverse musical expressions to enrich the cultural fabric of the DC music scene.

Strengthen Community Networks: Facilitate stronger networking opportunities through both virtual and in-person events, connecting music professionals with each other and with industry resources. Establish a mentor program.



Photos Courtesy of District of Columbia Commission on the Arts and Humanities

Opportunities (continued)

Improve Audience Engagement: Develop and promote tools and best practices for enhanced audience engagement, leveraging local media, gig calendars, and publicity resources.

Support Inclusivity and Equity: Implement programs and initiatives that address issues of elitism, sexism, and other barriers to inclusivity, promoting a more equitable and welcoming music community.

Leverage Local Talent: Encourage venues to prioritize booking local talent, creating more opportunities for local musicians and strengthening the connection between the community and its artists. Enhancing the Performing Arts Promotion Amendment (PAPA) Act Tax Rebate to create more opportunities for local talent.

Enhance Music Business Education: Offer more music business education courses to improve the professionalism and entrepreneurial acumen of artists, helping them to navigate and thrive in the industry. Create a revenue development program to help music professionals tap into the 100+ revenue streams for independent artists.

Enhance Music Licensing Education: Provide education and resources on music licensing and royalty collection to help creatives maximize their revenue streams and protect their intellectual property.



Photos Courtesy of District of Columbia Commission on the Arts and Humanities